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Follow Me

Today's Reading: John 1:43-51

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"He found Philip and said to him, 'Follow me.'...Nathanael said to him, 'How do you know me?' Jesus answered him, 'Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you.'"

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There are two great truths Jesus reveals to us here. They are found in how he called two of his disciples.

First, look at how Jesus called Philip. He found him in Galilee and simply said to him, "Follow me." Jesus didn't call Philip to follow a set of rules and regulations. No, he called him to follow himself. Jesus invited Philip to live as he lived—to emulate him and let his life flow through him. He would change Philip from the inside/out. That's what would happen as he followed Jesus, who calls you to follow him as well.

Second, note that Philip went and found his friend Nathanael. He told him he had found the Messiah, the one to whom the Law and prophets pointed.

Initially, Nathanael doubted Jesus. He had heard Jesus was from Nazareth. He didn't think anything good could come from Nazareth. His heart was filled with prejudice.

When Nathanael finally did come, Jesus already felt great love toward him. He knew what was in Nathanael's heart—even his prejudice. Before Nathanael ever approached Jesus, Jesus supernaturally saw him sitting under a fig tree—a symbol for the nation of Israel. Nathanael was struggling with why God's people had wandered so far from the Father's intentions. Why were they under Roman occupation and oppression?

Nathanael's heart was seeking truth. He didn't know that God's truth was already seeking him. Before Nathanael ever came to Jesus, the Lord already knew him and his heart. Long before he ever chose Jesus, Nathanael had already been chosen to follow him. Before Nathanael ever loved Jesus, the Lord first loved him.

Jesus was waiting to replace Nathanael's prejudice with his unconditional love.

Today, know that Jesus wants you to follow him. Your life is found in him. With everything you face today, simply follow him. Imitate him. Do what he calls you to do. Listen to his still, small voice within you. He will lead and guide you.

And know how much Jesus loves you. He loved you before this world was created. He knows all your struggles, doubts, questions, prejudices, and meanderings. Even while you were sinning, Jesus had chosen to die on the cross to forgive your sins.

He saw you before you ever saw him. He chose to love you before you ever chose to love him. You can't begin to imagine what Jesus has prepared for you.

Rest in these realities today...and forever.

[from "Hearing the Voice of God" by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]